Dvar Torah: Parshas Ki Sisa

The Strength of Being Human: Falling, Rising, and the Gift of Teshuvah

The Foundation: Being Human Before Being Jewish

Parshas Ki Sisa contains one of the most dramatic moments in Jewish history: the Chet HaEgel, the sin of the Golden Calf. It's a story that shocks us every time we read it. How could the same nation that stood at Har Sinai, that witnessed the miracles of Yetzias Mitzrayim, that heard the voice of Hashem directly, how could they fall so quickly into such a catastrophic mistake?

But before diving into the story itself, there's a fundamental principle that needs to be established. Every parsha has unique and profound lessons for every person in every generation. That's the nature of Torah. It's timeless, always relevant, always speaking to exactly where we are. And when looking at the arc of Sefer Shemos, when tracing the themes and patterns that define what it means to be a Jew, one truth emerges above all others:

To be a Jew, you must first be a human being.

People forget this. There's sometimes an impulse to think that Judaism asks us to transcend our humanity, to become something closer to angels. But that's not the Torah's vision at all.

We Are Not Malachim

Malachim exist in a different reality entirely. They don't struggle with uncertainty, with fear, with conflicting emotions. They don't make mistakes. They serve Hashem in a world of pure spirituality, untouched by the messiness of physical existence.

We've spoken about this over recent parshiyos, and the contrast appears most clearly on Yom Kippur. On that one day of the year, we dress in white like malachim. We don't eat or drink. We abstain from physical pleasures. We reach for that malach-level existence, trying to touch something beyond our ordinary human experience.

But Yom Kippur is one day.

And the Torah gives us another model, another day that sits on the same spiritual plane but expresses holiness in exactly the opposite way.

Purim: The Holiness of Being Human

This week we just celebrated Purim. The Zohar teaches something remarkable: "פורים אתקריאת על שם יום הכפורים" (Tikkunei Zohar 57b) - "Purim is called by the name of Yom HaKippurim." Purim and Yom Kippur, connected at the deepest level, representing two sides of the same spiritual reality.

But where Yom Kippur separates us from physicality, Purim embraces it. We feast. We drink. We dance and sing and celebrate with our bodies, not despite them. We experience simcha through physical enjoyment, through friendship, through the world of taste and sound and connection.

This is Matan Torah Sheni, the second giving of the Torah, as Chazal teach. And it happens not through transcending our humanity, but through elevating it.

Because we are human beings. And human beings living with Torah means bringing kedusha into the physical world, not escaping from it.

There are stories that remind us of this truth. The famous tale of the golem, who wanted to join a minyan but couldn't. Why? Because ultimately, something that imitates a person is still not actually human. A minyan requires human beings. Tefillah requires human beings. Torah requires human beings.

You have to be human to be a Jew.

The Context: Where We Are in the Sefer

To understand the Chet HaEgel, we need to step back and see where this parsha sits in the larger arc of Sefer Shemos.

The sefer begins with a transition. The era of the Avos has ended. The era of the shevatim, Yaakov Avinu's sons, has ended as well. A period of heavy darkness descends. The Jews are in exile, in galus, enslaved in Mitzrayim.

During that period of darkness, the Jews became confused. Some became involved with avodah zarah. This was before Matan Torah, before the great commandment given in Parshas Yisro: "אָנֹכִי ה' אֱלֹקֶיךָ... לֹא יִהְיֶה לְךָ אֱלֹהִים אֲחֵרִים עַל פָּנָי" (Shemos 20:2-3) - "I am Hashem your God... You shall have no other gods before Me," the prohibition against placing any other god before Hashem.

But here's something crucial: even those who had been involved with avodah zarah were taken out of Mitzrayim. Hashem understood that we are human. The redemption came first. The clarity would come later.

From that point forward, through all the parshiyos leading up to Ki Sisa, Hashem has been directly and actively involved in the lives of the Jewish people. The makkos. The splitting of the Yam Suf. The mon falling from heaven. Matan Torah itself at Har Sinai.

Hashem's presence has been unmistakable, undeniable, constantly visible.

And yet, only a short time after Sinai, they stumble again.

Before the Fall: The Ketores

Before we get to the Eigel, the parsha opens with the commandment of the ketores, the incense offering. The ketores is extraordinary. Chazal teach that the ketores was even stronger than the korbanos. The proof? By Korach's rebellion, when a plague was sweeping through the camp killing people, it was the ketores that stopped it.

The very same thing that can bring destruction can also bring healing.

This is a reminder we've seen before: the cure comes before the disease, before the ailment. Rashi is quick to remind us that the Torah doesn't always follow chronological order. The Torah teaches according to meaning, according to instruction.

Last week's parsha, Tetzaveh, was the one where Moshe Rabbeinu's name is not mentioned. And many connect that to this week's parsha, where Moshe tells Hashem: if You are going to wipe these people out, then wipe me out as well.

The ketores comes first. The healing is already prepared. Because what's about to happen will require healing.

The Miscalculation

Now we arrive at the central event: the Chet HaEgel.

Moshe Rabbeinu told the Jewish people that he would be back after forty days. But the commentaries explain that there was a miscalculation. Was he coming down on the fortieth day, or maybe on the fortieth night? Did they start counting by night, or did they start counting by day?

The long and the short of it: the people made a mistake.

Actually, they made several mistakes.

But mistake number one was that they made an Eigel Zahav, a Golden Calf.

Think about this for a moment. No matter how many miscalculations there were along the way, no matter the confusion about timing, everything they had just been through should have prevented this. Everything. The makkos. The Yam Suf. The mon. Sinai itself.

Hashem had been directly, visibly, undeniably present in their lives.

And still, when Moshe was a few hours late coming down the mountain, they panicked.

The Torah describes the moment: "וַיַּרְא הָעָם כִּי בֹשֵׁשׁ מֹשֶׁה לָרֶדֶת מִן הָהָר" (Shemos 32:1) - "The people saw that Moshe delayed coming down from the mountain."

Without Moshe's leadership, confusion spread. Fear replaced faith. Uncertainty led to a demand for something visible, something tangible, something they could see and touch.

In that moment of weakness, they turned to Aharon and demanded a physical symbol to lead them forward.

That request became the Eigel HaZahav.

What Was Hashem Expecting?

But here's where we need to ask a deeper question.

What was Hashem expecting?

The reality is that Hashem knows everything. He knew how this was going to play out. He knew about the miscalculation. He knew about the panic. He knew about the Eigel.

So why did it have to happen this way?

Because something had to be revealed. Something that couldn't be taught any other way.

Am Kesheh Oref: The Stiff-Necked People

Hashem describes the Jewish people with a striking phrase: "עַם קְשֵׁה עֹרֶף הוּא" (Shemos 32:9) - "Am kesheh oref," a stiff-necked people.

At first glance, this sounds entirely negative. Stubbornness. Rigidity. An inability to bend or adapt or listen.

But there's something profound hidden in this description.

Because Hashem was teaching the Jewish people something essential about themselves. Something they would need for the rest of history.

They had to learn what it means to do teshuvah.

They had to learn what it means to repair mistakes. Not always to the extreme of death, although some people did die. But to understand that people make mistakes. That human beings stumble. That failure is part of the human condition.

And that there is always an opportunity to return.

To do teshuvah is human. To do teshuvah is Jewish. It is part of what makes us who we are.

The Two-Part Test

It could be that Hashem was saying something like this:

"I know what you are going to do. I know what will happen when Moshe Rabbeinu is two hours late coming down the mountain. So let's make this a teaching moment."

On one level, this was a test for the people at the bottom of the mountain. What would they do when Moshe didn't return at the expected time?

But it was really a two-part test.

Part one: what would the people do in Moshe's absence?

Part two: what would happen after they got into trouble? How would Moshe Rabbeinu respond?

And the story that unfolds becomes much deeper than it would have been otherwise.

Because before this, the plan was simple. Moshe would come down with the Luchos. Everyone would celebrate. They would receive the Torah and begin an avodah based on the Aseres HaDibros.

But instead, something much more powerful emerged.

Azus D'Kedusha: Holy Boldness

Rabbi Nachman of Breslov teaches in Likutei Moharan (Chelek Aleph, Torah 22) about a concept called azus d'kedusha. A kind of brazen spiritual boldness, a holy audacity.

This concept appears everywhere in Torah thought: almost every human emotion, every character trait, can exist in two directions.

Love can become lust, destructive and self-serving. Or it can become pure love that brings a person closer to Hashem.

Hatred can become sinas chinam, baseless hatred that destroyed the Beis HaMikdash. But we are also commanded to hate Amalek.

The difference isn't in the emotion itself. It's in how we direct it, how we elevate it, how we channel it toward kedusha.

As we've said before: to be mesaken on our middos means that our middos, in turn, refine us.

And we see the first major expression of azus d'kedusha right here in Parshas Ki Sisa.

Moshe's Challenge

Moshe Rabbeinu directly challenges Hashem.

"If You are going to wipe these people out, then wipe me out also, because I do not want to be here without them."

He reminds Hashem of the promises made to the Avos. To Avraham, to Yitzchak, to Yaakov.

Of course, Hashem knows what He promised. Hashem knows everything. He knows the past and the future, every detail, every possibility.

But Moshe needed to say it.

He needed to say it for himself and for future generations.

Because through that moment, something new was revealed.

Moshe then makes an even bolder request. He asks Hashem to reveal His name, to reveal His glory.

"הַרְאֵנִי נָא אֶת כְּבֹדֶךָ" (Shemos 33:18) - "Show me, please, Your glory."

Hashem responds that Moshe can see His back, but he cannot see His face. "כִּי לֹא יִרְאַנִי הָאָדָם וָחָי" (Shemos 33:20) - "For no human can see My face and live."

And from there, we receive one of the greatest gifts in all of Torah: the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy.

"Hashem, Hashem, Kel Rachum v'Chanun..."

"ה' ה' אֵ-ל רַחוּם וְחַנּוּן אֶרֶךְ אַפַּיִם וְרַב חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת..." (Shemos 34:6)

Whenever we are in trouble, these are the words we turn to. During the Yamim Noraim, during times of crisis, during moments when we need Hashem's compassion most desperately.

These words are real. They are powerful. They are a direct channel to Hashem's mercy.

And they emerged from this moment. From the aftermath of failure. From the recognition that human beings stumble, and that Hashem's response is not only justice, but also compassion.

The True Meaning of Sorry

This brings us to something essential about teshuvah, about what it really means to say "I'm sorry."

This is something worth teaching our children. When you say you're sorry, the question isn't just about expressing regret. The question is: what are you going to do about it next time?

Apologies without change are meaningless. If you're simply going to repeat the same mistake, then "I'm sorry" is just noise.

What matters is growth. Learning. Becoming better. Strengthening our relationships with each other and with Hashem.

We learn not to repeat the same mistakes. We become better people, better human beings interacting with one another in a more elevated way.

That's the message of teshuvah. That's what the Chet HaEgel came to teach.

The Malachim's Challenge

There's a beautiful teaching based on the Gemara about when Moshe Rabbeinu went up to receive the Torah.

When he ascended to receive the Luchos, the malachim challenged him. They protested again and again: Why should the Torah be given to human beings? Why not keep it in the spiritual realm?

They argued that they are partners with Hashem, that they are closer to Him, that they are more worthy.

They presented all sorts of malach-level arguments.

But at the end of it all, the answer is very simple.

First, the Torah is a yerusha to us, an inheritance. It belongs to the Jewish people by right.

But more importantly, the purpose of Torah is that it is meant to be lived in this world.

This world is upside down. We see change. We see opposites. We see kedusha and we see the opposite of kedusha.

Within the Jewish world and outside of it, we see people strengthening their connection to Torah and we see others arguing against it.

And yet Torah continues to enter our lives day by day, moment by moment.

The Torah speaks about honoring parents. About business dealings. About jealousy. About mistakes. About repentance.

Malachim don't live in that world. Human beings do.

Torah was given to be lived in the complicated, messy, beautiful reality of human life.

The Gift, Sometimes Painful

Torah is a gift. Sometimes it's a painful gift. Growth often hurts. Change often requires discomfort. Learning from our mistakes can be excruciating.

But it's still a gift.

As we enter this week's parsha, there's something crucial to remember:

We can fall. And we will fall.

But we can also get back up.

And when we do, we can build a better relationship. A deeper relationship. A relationship forged not only in moments of revelation, but also in moments of repair.

The Second Luchos

After the Chet HaEgel, Moshe Rabbeinu goes back up the mountain. He creates the second Luchos. He receives additional mitzvos.

And something is different this time.

The first Luchos were simply given. They were a pure gift from Hashem, carved by Hashem Himself, descending from the heavens fully formed.

The second Luchos had to be carved by Moshe himself. He had to work for them. He had to sweat. It was no longer just a simple gift handed down from above.

There's a profound lesson here: sometimes the things we have to work for, the things we have to earn through effort and struggle, become more precious to us than the things that come easily.

The first Luchos were broken. The second Luchos endured.

Moshe's Shining Face

When Moshe comes back down from the mountain, the Torah tells us something remarkable: "וְהִנֵּה קָרַן עוֹר פָּנָיו" (Shemos 34:29) - "Behold, the skin of his face was radiant."

Moshe's face shines.

But here's the striking detail: Moshe himself doesn't even realize it.

"וּמֹשֶׁה לֹא יָדַע כִּי קָרַן עוֹר פָּנָיו" (Shemos 34:29) - "Moshe did not know that the skin of his face was radiant."

And that's how growth often works.

As we grow day by day, moment by moment, we don't necessarily see it ourselves. We're too close to our own process. We're living inside our own transformation.

It often takes someone else to notice it. To point it out. To reflect back to us the changes they see.

Learning and Growing Together

There's a practice that happens in some chaburos, in close learning partnerships and groups. Periodically, they pause and reflect on the changes and growth they see in one another over time.

Because there is no such thing as finishing Torah. Even after smicha, the learning continues. Torah is timeless, infinite, always revealing new layers.

One practice involves pausing together and asking: What growth do we see in each other? Where have we changed? Where have we strengthened?

Of course, we have to do our own cheshbon hanefesh, our own personal accounting. We speak about doing that during Elul, during the month of teshuvah.

But sometimes it's also powerful to have someone else reflect on us. To hear what they see. To receive their perspective on our growth.

To point out areas where we've grown and areas where we can still grow.

A Practice for This Week

Maybe this week is an opportunity for something like that.

Not only personal reflection, but also group reflection.

If there's a close group in your life, a family member, a chavrusa, a chavurah, maybe have that conversation. Maybe one-on-one. Maybe with a spouse.

But it must be done carefully. With kindness. With compassion.

Because honesty without compassion can become cruelty.

Real feedback, the kind that helps us grow, must come with care. It must be given in a spirit of love and genuine desire to help the other person become their best self.

But when done properly, it's transformative.

Highlight the positive growth. Acknowledge the effort. Celebrate the changes, even the small ones.

Because that's what teshuvah is about. That's what being human is about.

Falling, yes. But also rising. Learning. Growing. Becoming better versions of ourselves, day by day.

The Stubbornness That Saves Us

Let's return to that phrase: Am kesheh oref. A stiff-necked people.

Yes, it led to the Eigel. Stubbornness, when misdirected, leads to rebellion and error.

But that same stubbornness, when channeled properly, becomes persistence. Resilience. The refusal to abandon faith even in the most difficult moments of history.

It's the same trait that has allowed the Jewish people to survive exile after exile, persecution after persecution, century after century of challenge and hardship.

We are stubborn. And sometimes that stubbornness creates problems.

But it's also the stubbornness that preserves the covenant with Hashem. That refuses to let go. That says, even when everything seems lost, we're not giving up.

The trait that led to the Chet HaEgel is the same trait that has kept us alive for thousands of years.

Questions for Your Shabbos Table

As we reflect on the lessons of Ki Sisa, consider these questions:

On Being Human:

- Where in my life am I trying to be a malach instead of embracing my humanity?
- How can I bring more kedusha into my physical reality rather than trying to escape it?

On Teshuvah:

- When I apologize, do I focus only on expressing regret, or do I also commit to real change?
- What mistake have I made that I can now transform into growth?

On Stubbornness:

- Where is my "stiff-necked" nature hurting me, and where is it actually keeping me strong?
- How can I channel my persistence toward kedusha rather than toward resistance?

Closing: The Rebuilding

As we close this Shabbos, there's something to keep in mind.

All signs point toward the rebuilding of the Beis HaMikdash. The world is changing. History is accelerating.

We should all be safe. We should all be well.

And we should merit to see the rebuilding very soon.

Not because we're perfect. Not because we never fall.

But because we're human. Because we do teshuvah. Because we know how to rise after we fall.

Because we received the second Luchos, the ones that came through work and sweat and repair.

And those Luchos, forged in the fire of failure and return, are the ones that endure.

May we continue to grow, to learn from our mistakes, to support one another, and to build a dwelling place for Hashem not only in the Mishkan, but in our hearts.

Have a wonderful Shabbos.

Gut Shabbos!